

Home Minister, R.R. Patil, with the result that signals are confused and Raj ends up being treated with kid gloves. If they have any excuse for that approach, it can only be that they are taking their cue from the Central leadership which has refrained from any outright condemnation or action to neutralise the MNS menace. AICC general secretary in charge of Maharashtra, Margaret Alva, usually vocal and outspoken on most issues concerning the state, has been conspicuous by her silence. For Mumbai, a city under increasing siege, the ultimate twist of irony is that Raj broke from the Shiv Sena saying, in his resignation letter to his uncle, that he wanted to promote a "modern and progressive state".

From his recent antics, his dream of a modern and progressive state is everyone else's nightmare. As a gunman hijacking a state transport bus in broad daylight fill television screens one day and mindless rioting and arson the other, India has reason to be worried each time Raj dreams. Inciting extremism will have its own repercussions but the state's politicians are oblivious to such a threat as all that they are concerned about is combating the growing influence of Mayawati's Bahujan Samaj Party and Mulayam Singh Yadav's Samajwadi Party. With governance collapsing in Maharashtra, the state machinery has lost the will to combat extremist forces.

The MNS and its naked violence has claimed many victims, but most of them are those who are powerless in the face of such aggression. Taxis and autos are possibly the worst hit by any polit-



IN COLD BLOOD: Rahul Raj was shot dead by police in a bus

ical agitation, as in any mob violence public transport becomes the first target. Last week, the MNS supporters hit the streets and burnt taxis and auto-rickshaws in such a way that nobody was willing to go anywhere near Bandra Court the day Raj was arrested and brought to the court. The fear of being attacked made drivers park their vehicles and refuse to move. Says A.L. Quadros, president, Bombay Taximan's Union: "Taxi and rickshaw workers are on the road and are attacked in by-lanes where no one can see them. They are not even given any claim as most drivers are daily wage workers." Obviously, rioting hits them hard financially.

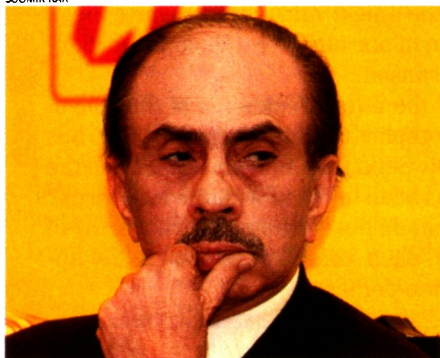
“ WE SHOULD GIVE THE POLICE CARTE BLANCHE TO DEAL WITH THE SITUATION. THEY NEED POLITICAL AND LEGAL BACK-UP. ”

DEEPAK PAREKH, CHAIRMAN, HDFC BANK



BHASKAR PAUL

SOUMIK KAR



“ IT'S NOT A DESIRABLE TREND. TAKING UP THE CAUSE OF ONE SEGMENT IS NOT RIGHT. LET'S TAKE UP THE CAUSE OF INDIA. ”

ADI GODREJ, CHAIRMAN, GODREJ INDUSTRIES